

Participant Information Sheet

Study title: Rating retrieval quality of a query by vocal imitation system

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Queen Mary Ethics of research Committee reference number: DSEEC525.073

Thank you for helping us improve sound search through vocal imitation. This short guide explains what you'll be asked to do.

What this study is about

- We are testing a system that lets people search for sounds by imitating them with their voice (e.g., saying “woof woof” to find a dog bark).
- Your feedback will help us build a public dataset for research and improve sound search technology.

What you will do

1. Record a sound imitation (up to 10 seconds). Please avoid real words or identifiable speech — just make the sound you want.
2. The system will retrieve similar sounds from its database.
3. Listen to the results and tell us if you like or dislike each sound as a match.
4. When you are done, submit your ratings so they are saved.

Important notes

- Data collection is off by default. You will be asked to consent if you want your recordings and ratings included in the study.
- You can turn data collection off again at any time.
- Recordings are short (max 10 seconds) and should not include normal speech.
- No personal information apart from the audio query is collected.
- The audio query and responses will be stored in encrypted storage.

Why participate

You'll be contributing to open research that will help create better tools for sound search and human–computer interaction.

Elibility

Participants must be over 18 years old.

Do I have to take part?

This participant information sheet has been written to help you decide if you would like to take part in this study. It is entirely up to you whether you wish to take part. If you do decide to take part you will be free to withdraw at any time without needing to provide a reason, and with no penalties or detrimental effects.

During the entire duration of the study, you are free to not answer or not take part in the discussion/activities at any moment in time if you don't feel so. You can always withdraw at any point of the session, without needing to provide a reason and with no penalties or detrimental effects

What are the possible benefits of taking part?

Taking part in this study will give you the possibility to directly contribute to the research of vocal imitation development. Another benefits is the contribution to scientific research on models that could benefit sound design.

What are the possible disadvantages and risks of taking part?

There is a risk to having a vocal recording public, even if other information is anonymised, because someone might still be able to identify the person in the recording from their voice. We are doing several things to minimise and hopefully completely eliminate this risk. We ask you to only submit non-speech vocalisations, which are very unlikely to be identifiable. We will use an automatic process to filter out any speech from the collected data, before doing a manual review of all data to ensure there are no identifiable vocal characteristics.

What information about me will you be collecting?

Only the query audio recording and your rating.

How will my data be stored and who will have access to it?

The voice recordings will be temporarily stored on an encrypted Vercel Blob storage instance, until being transferred to a secure server owned by Queen Mary University of London; any other elaboration of the data (eg. analysis etc.) will be stored in fully anonymized digital format in the same storage space. Upon analysis for suitability, the data will be shared public as part of a public dataset.

Under what legal basis are you collecting this information?

Queen Mary University of London processes personal data for research purposes in accordance with the lawful basis of 'public task'.

Please read Queen Mary's privacy notice for research participants containing important information about your personal data and your rights in this respect.

If you have any questions relating to data protection, please contact Queen Mary's Data Protection Officer, Queens' Building, Mile End Road, London, E1 4NS or data-protection@qmul.ac.uk or 020 7882 7596.

What will happen if I want to withdraw from this study?

Participants can withdraw from the study at any point in time by simply leaving the website or turning data sharing off, without needing to provide a reason and with no penalties or detrimental effects.

What should I do if I have any concerns about this study?

If you have any concerns about the manner in which the study was conducted, in the first instance, please contact the researcher(s) responsible for the study. If you have a complaint which you feel you cannot discuss with the researchers then you should contact the Research Ethics Facilitators by e-mail: research-ethics@qmul.ac.uk. When contacting the Research Ethics Facilitators, please provide details of the study title, description of the

study and QMERC reference number (where possible), the researcher(s) involved, and details of the complaint you wish to make.

Who can I contact if I have any questions about this study?

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